Shakumbhari Devi shrine. BJP leaders say that his presence changed the local poll dynamics. A senior official put it thus: 'In western UP, we knew there would be a big impact if Yogiji went. People said he won't have any impact there, but we knew BJP will rise there and so as he went. You must understand Muslims in western UP are well off, rich and dominant. The Muslim there is not only economically rich but physically big too. He is not like a weak person. He gives you an equal challenge, he fights, he does division of assets, takes you on when it comes to land, on markets. He confronts you on everything. So, Hindu messaging works there.'[13]

It is not only in UP that the polarising impact is seen. This effect is exactly why, after Modi and Amit Shah, Yogi Adityanath remains the most sought-after leader in the BJP for state units fighting elections. BJP leaders understood his potential as a vote-catcher and catalyst for Hindu consolidation, especially in areas with a Muslim presence, over a decade ago. In Chhapra, Bihar, for example, the journalist Sanjeev Singh recalls that, even in 2005, people used to ask for Yogi to campaign. 'The calculation in those days was that if you got him for a meeting, it would make a difference of 5,000 Hindu votes. But yes, you would then not get a single Muslim vote. The Hindu vote, you would cement though.' It is not a coincidence that, in the Bihar assembly polls of November 2020, Yogi Adityanath was the most sought-after non-local BJP star campaigner after Modi.[14] The results showed that he ended up having a 66.6 per cent strike-rate in the constituencies he travelled to.[15] In the 2019 general election too, Yogi was the most in-demand BJP chief minister for the party's official election rallies. He addressed more rallies than any other BJP chief minister: 135. This was followed by Jai Ram Thakur with 106, Devendra Fadnavis with ninety-one, Vijay Rupani with eighty-six and Vijendra Singh Rawat with fifty-eight.[16] While all parties tend to designate their star campaigners, the number of rallies they actually address is often indicative of how much local candidates think they will add to their chances of winning. Yogi Adityanath's in-demand status as a campaigner, in that sense, reflects instrumental judgements on his impact that the party was making, not just ideological signalling.